Individual Report

How Different Dimensions of Perceived Fit Influence Consumer Responses to Gordon's × Sprite Citrus Clarity

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BUYER BEHAVIOUR

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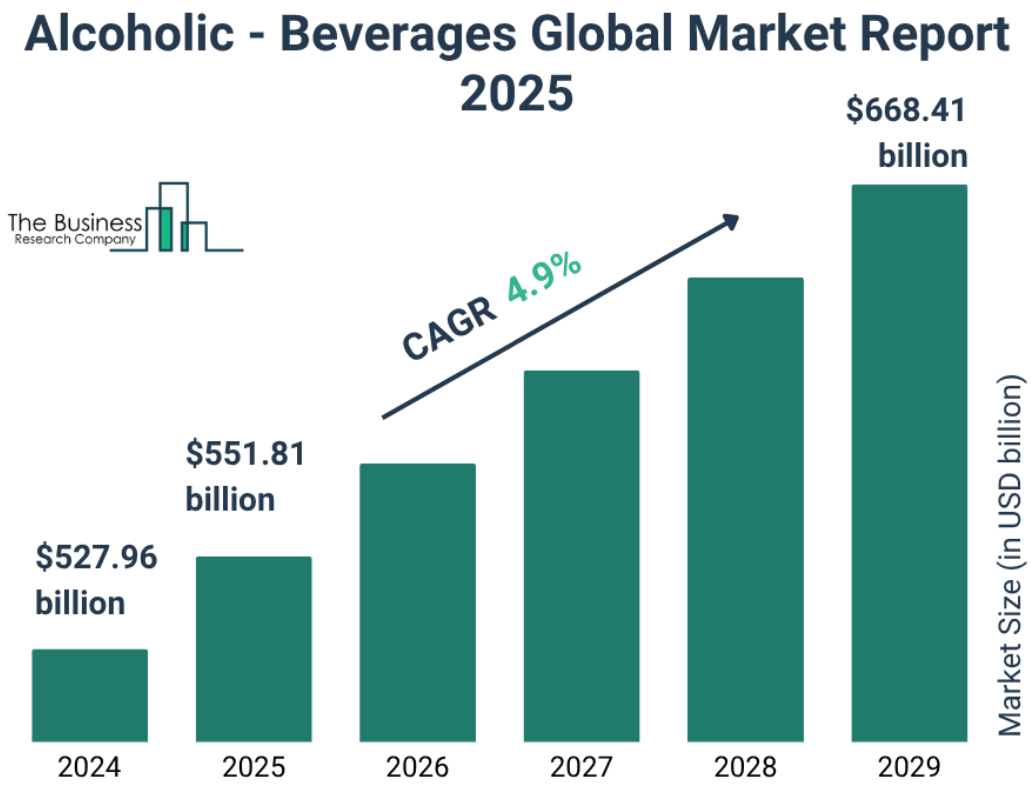
1.0 Executive Summary

Three key aspects of perceived fit, namely product-category fit, image fit, and values fit, and influence consumer attitudes, perceived quality and risk, and purchase intentions toward Gordon x Sprite citrus Clarity, a premium ready-to-drink (RTD) gin cocktail developed in this report. Basing its analysis on co-branding literature, it has been found that the fit of products and their categories take advantage of already existing consumer mixing behaviour, whereas image fit is not simple to reconcile premium spirits positioning with mass-market

soft drinks linkages (Koskie, and Locander, 2023). The value fit becomes especially influential, and the focus of both brands on the authenticity and quality is likely to address the perceptual incongruities.

2.0 Introduction

Co-branding is a form of strategic alliance involving two existing brands merging to form a separate product with the strength of both parent brands and cooperation. This could be followed in the case of the Gordon and Sprite partnership, which combines the world leading selling gin with Coca-Cola classic lemon-lime drink in its signature Citrus Clarity, a high end RTD cocktail. As the RTD market in the UK is predicted to be € 2.1 billion by 2026 and expanding at 30% per annum, it would be commercially essential to comprehend how customers view such kind of brand association (Koskie, and Locander, 2023).



Alcoholic - Beverages Global Market Report 2025 (World Health Organization, 2025)

The basis of co-branding success is the element of perceived fit which is a measurement of the perceived compatibility and complement of two brands by the consumer. Pedeliento, Pinchera, and Andreini (2022) believe that the transformation of any brand into a symbol of the marketplace as the consumption patterns are being influenced by the mixer preferences and convenience factors more and more (Gordon, Balta-Ozkan, and Nabavi, 2024). But perceived fit is never a single aspect and therefore it consists of several dimensions that differ in terms of how they work according to different psychological processes.

This report is a critical analysis of three-dimension core elements of perceived fit (product-category fit, image fit, and values fit) and their corresponding effects on consumer reactions to Citrus Clarity.

3.0 Product-Category Status Fit and Applicability.

3.1: Product-category Fit Conceptualization.

The perceived complementariness of product category and functional attributes of partner brands is called product-category fit. The dimension dwells on the sense of consumers perceiving the combination as natural and logical allowing consideration of their product knowledge and consumption habits. According to Rua and Santos (2022), when considering the idea of brand positioning and competitive advantage, the organisation must exclude any careless thoughts about the compatibility of product combinations with the set consumer expectations.

Product-category fit is exceptionally high in the case of x Sprite made by Gordon. The partnership essentially pre-mixes what is already being done by two in-thirds of the gin drinkers, which is adding gin to lemon-lime cocktails. The Citrus Clarity by codifying an existing consumer behaviour is a beneficial approach because natural fit can be realised in the scenario whereby the product combination resembles the usage patterns. Johnson, Verster, and Alford (2022) investigated the phenomenon of mixing spirits and found that consumers exhibit unambiguous preferences concerning a certain brand-mixture combination depending on the compatibility of the tastes and social appropriateness in their tastes.

The rational compatibility of the product would be made by the functional synergy of botanical complicacy of Gordon and crisp citrus profile of Sprite. Gordon also incorporates its triple-distilled gin experience with its secret botanical blend with juniper, coriander and citrus traces, and Sprite adds its natural lemon-lime flavouring that was re-formulated

recently. This complementarity implies that the two brands have different functional expertise to the end product (Lemmens, et al., 2025).

3.2 Effect on Perceived Quality and Risk.

Product-category fit has two main effects on influence of perceived quality and they are transferable expertise and functional synergy. Gordon has gin making expertise and Sprite mixer formulation capabilities that are seen by the consumers. The study by Situmorang et al. (2021) has reported that the brand positioning was significantly related to the repurchase intention via the intermediating position of attitude towards brand implying that explicit functional complementary role contributes to positive evaluation of quality (Lemmens, et al., 2025).

Nevertheless, the effect of product-category fit on perceived risk is not easy. Although the concept of functional complementarity lowers the risk of performance (consumers believe that the brands can provide the desired taste experience), there is the likelihood that the financial risk perception might be created by the premium positioning. Citrus Clarity is positioned at a middle-level of superior pricing at € 6 to € 8 per four packs. It is difficult to explain premium pricing to what the consumers may likely see as essentially simple, which is gin and lemon-lime soda together.

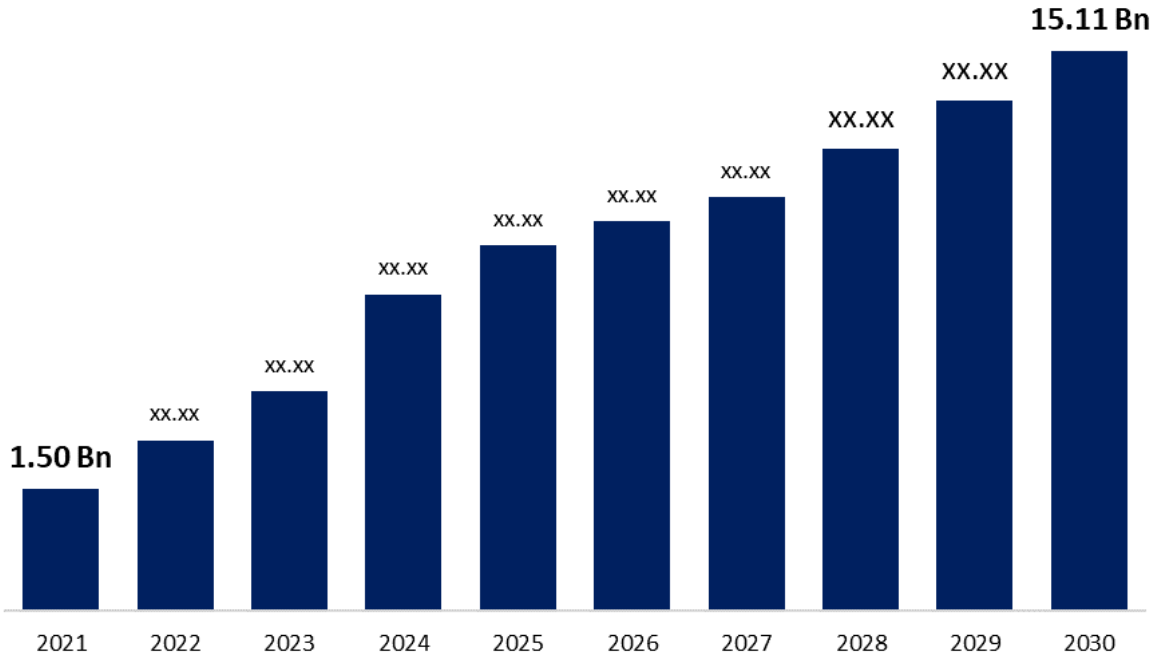
4.0 Image Fit and Brand Association Congruence

4.1 Fit Image Understanding Difficulties.

Image fit regards the perceived similarity between personalities of partner brands, the image, and the positioning strategy of the brands. This dimension is more compound as compared to product fit in the sense that it touches on the emotional subjective brand associations.

Gordon positioning can be viewed as classy but affordable, which focuses on 250-year-old traditions, triple distillation and private botanical formulations. The brand will be of mid-to premium prices (€ 15 to € 20 bottle) that are sold by its distributors, mostly consisting of liquor specialists and top-end retailers. On the other hand, Sprite is mass-market positioned, has universal access, youth orientation, and premises on the message of Obey Your Thirst that revolves around the elements of authentic self-expression (Wongkitrungrueng, and Suprawan, 2024).

Fayvishenko (2018) underlines that the formation of brand positioning must take into account the consistency or the disharmony of positioning strategy in case of collaboration between brands. The image incongruity lies in the position difference between the premium heritage storey that Gordon is portraying and Sprite that is targeting a youth-based mass-market. This is more pronounced in high-end market joint ventures since consumers doubt either the high-end brand cannot be beige to mass but instead the mass brand can be refined to high-end or the high-end brand lacks the refinement needed in mass situations.



Alcohol Ingredients Market Size, Global Analysis, Forecast 2030 (Mäntylä Baeza, 2012)

4.2 Effect on the Attitudes of the Consumer.

Through the affect transfer mechanisms, image fit can play a very important role in overall attitudes towards co-branded products. This is however very different depending on the consumer segment. Through its associations with young people, Sprite can actually increase its appeal in the young millennials (25 to 35 years) who are the target audience of Citrus Clarity. This generation of people has been brought up believing in Sprite as a ubiquitous beverage and they will not see mass-market positioning as something that will not be compatible with the premium consumption (Wongkitrungrueng, and Suprawan, 2024).

On the other hand, older consumers (35 to 45 years) who have stronger investments in conventional high-quality spirits indicators may also consider that the Sprite alliance weakens the brand as a source of prestige of Gordon. These consumers usually keep more tangible hierarchical reasons between high-end brands and mass-market ones, and fear partnerships between those bounds.

By repositioning the idea of convenience as democratising the premium experiences, the effortless premium positioning strategy seems to fill this gap in image. This positioning is an attempt to address image incongruity because the new category space is established where the high quality and the accessibility of the mass market are mutually consistent.

4.3 Quality and Risk Perceptions

Image fit has complicated impacts on perceived quality and risk. In a premium brand-mass-market brand association, the quality perception tends to stick at the premium partner especially when the premium brand propels the association in a visible manner like it is in the case of the naming convention of Gordon (Wongkitrungrueng, and Suprawan, 2024).

Image incongruity in its turn can contradictorily contribute to perceived risk by a number of mechanisms. To begin with, the consumers who are well accustomed to Gordon in the conventional spirits landscape may find the pre-mixed and canned packaging format unreliable, and be confounded by whether quality will be transferred to this new package. Second, Sprite association can create the issue of quality concerns concerning the mass-production processes. Even though Sprite has been recently repackaged with fully natural flavours, people might not be aware of this yet, as compared to the reality whose external has been improved.

5.0 Values Sympathetic Compatibility and Symbolic Fit

5.1 Shared Values in the Form of Cohesive Force.

Values fit is the most profound aspect of perceived fit when it comes to the alignment of the core values, beliefs, and principles that are embodied by brands. In contrast to product or image fit, the value fit works with deeper levels of identification in which consumers see if the collaboration makes sense in their own values and self-image.

Gordon and Sprite have a number of core values which make the values fit even though the positioning of the brands may be superficial. Both focus on authenticity: through its history and natural methods of production that date back more than 250 years, Sprite because of its recent redesign with 100% natural flavours and Obey Your Thirst authenticity message. Both are more focused on quality ingredients over artificial additives with Gordon being more focused on botanical purity and Sprite on it abandoning the use of artificial ingredients (Lee, et al., 2024).

Naturally, a focus on natural formulations symbolises especially high values congruity. In the case of Citrus Clarity, this values congruence formed by common beliefs of using natural ingredients is appropriate among target customers have values congruence that speaks strongly to many since they are millennials and paying more attention to ingredient labels than ever. The designation of the zero artificial sweeteners, natural flavours precisely deals with the consumer values, which are connected with clean ingredients.

5.2 Effect on Consumer Relationships and Attitudes to the Brand.

Values fit is relevant because it prevents consumer attitudes through the process of self-congruency. Consumers will have a more favourable attitude towards the brand that is viewed to be in line with the self-concept and value they hold. The effect of self-congruency increases when two brands with congruent values work together as the partnership can strengthen instead of contradicting the values the consumers attribute to that particular brand.

To the consumer who values natural ingredients and genuineness, the combination of Gordon and x Sprite strengthens the values of the brands since both brands focus on natural formulas.

Such fit has the potential to produce a greater number of positive attitudes than image fit would have explained. Besides, value fit determines the intensity of consumer brand relations. Value based brand relationships are more resistant than image-based relationship due to the fact that they have been connected with stable self-believes as opposed to different preferences.

5.3 Purchase Intention Equity Values Matching.

The mechanism of values fit modulates the purchase intentions unlike the product or image fit. Though product fit and image fit do decrease the level of functional uncertainty and affective attraction respectively, values fit works on the moral and identity-driven incentives. When the consumers experience alignment of the values, then the decision to purchase is no longer price sensitive; this is due to the fact that consumers perceive purchase as an act of expressing values and not exactly as a functional decision making the purchase.

This is especially applicable in the case of premium pricing strategy of Citrus Clarity. Those consumers who are ready to spend € 6 to € 8 on four cans probably do it partly due to the fact that the purchase provides the expression of values such convenience, quality and the level of social sophistication. There is compatibility of the values between heritage-quality values of Gordon and authenticity-refreshment values of Sprite that form self-brand associations that warrant high prices through expressing identity.

6.0 Synergistic Effects and Strategic Implications.

6.1 Fit Dimension Interaction.

The three fit dimensions are not independent but they all interact to determine the overall consumer responses. In the case of x Sprite, evidence shows that on the one hand, exemplary product-category fit, and highly valued product-category fit can counteract medium issues of image fit, especially in the market among target millennials who do not attach much importance to the conventional premium-mass boundaries in the market.

The positioning Citrus Clarity making its name to be Effortless Premium seeks to rebrand the combination of Gordon and Spirits not as the occurrence of incongruence, but as creatively in-between the moments of consumption that had before been apart. This business approach establishes a new category of environment, in which high-quality products and accessibility in the mass market do not contradict each other.

The interdependence between values fit and image fit is to be considered specifically. While the image fit perceptions can positively be based on the strong values alignment on authenticity and natural ingredients, the system can be proactive to enhance such values fit perceptions by offering a consistent storey that supports and justifies the collaboration. As soon as the consumers realise that both brands have key values in terms of quality and authenticity, the premium-mass market positioning gap might not be seen as an issue.

6.2 Implication of the study to the various consumer segments.

Fit dimensions are likely to be of different weights to different consumer segments. In the case of convenient consumers who focus on utility benefits, the fit of a product category is more important. Image fit is paramount in the case of status-conscious consumers who would be interested in social signalling. Value fit can be the most effective to values-driven consumers (probably, the largest part of target millennials). According to Pedeliento, Pinchera, and Andreini (2022), the development of gin as a symbol of the market can be seen as a way of meeting the growing consumer demands in the sense that the traditional status characteristics are less important than the ones of heritage and authenticity.

This is because the RTD market is developing very fast by 30 percent a year posing both opportunities and challenges. According to Rua and Santos (2022), competitive advantage needs to establish sources of differentiation that are difficult to copy. In the case of Citrus Clarity, the competitive imitation is hindered by the unique selling element of the credibility of Gordon and the distribution strength possessed by Sprite. This distribution strength is a key consideration especially the distribution system used by Coca-Cola reaches 94% of all retail stores in the UK in comparison to the 43% of all traditional spirits distributors.

7.0 Conclusion

Perceived fit has three dimensions which have different, but the dimensions are related to consumer reactions to the x Sprite Citrus Clarity by Gordon. Product-category fit offers functional credibility and less performance risk through codifying the already existing

consumption behaviours. Image fit is problematic in that there are positioning differences but seems to be less wary among target millennials. Values fit comes up as the strongest dimension, and mutual dedication to authenticity, natural ingredients, and social delight form a strong resonance of values with target consumers.

The aggregate consumer attitudes, perceived quality and risk evaluation as well as purchase intentions are byproducts of the aggregate effects of all the three fit dimensions. To be successful, it seems important to Citrus Clarity to preserve the high product-category fit and be strategic in controlling the image fit perceptions and focusing on values congruence importance. The ultimate consideration of the commercial viability of collaborations will be the ability of the compensatory effects of exceptional product and values fit to adequately meet the moderate image fit problems.

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